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Language contact determines prosodic representation and variation

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1 Introduction

1.1 Diminutive structures in Standard Brazilian Portuguese

- In standard Brazilian Portuguese (ST-BP) varieties, lower mid vowels in the stem are preserved in diminutive constructions (with -iɲV/-ziɲV) (e.g., Câmara Jr. 1970, Lee 2013); see (1).

(1)	a.	vɛla + iɲV → vɛliɲa	'candle'
	b.	jakarɛ + ziɲV → jakarɛziɲo	'alligator'
	c.	bɔla + iɲV → bɔliɲa	'ball'
	d.	anzɔl + ziɲV → anzɔlziɲo	'fish hook'

1.2 Diminutive structures in another variety of Brazilian Portuguese

- In a southern variety of Brazilian Portuguese, namely the Italian Immigration Area variety (IIA-BP), there is variation in the production of lower mid vowels in diminutive constructions, which can be realized in three different ways: as lower mid, upper mid, or high vowels (Faggion 2006); see (2).

(2)	a.	vɛla + iɲV → vɛliɲa, veliɲa, viliɲa	'candle'
	b.	jakarɛ + ziɲV → jakarɛziɲo, jakarezi ɲo, jakariziɲo	'alligator'
	c.	bɔla + iɲV → bɔliɲa, boliɲa, buliɲa	'ball'
	d.	anzɔl + ziɲV → anzɔlziɲo, anzolziɲo, anzulziɲo	'fish hook'

- Upper mid vowels in the stem can be realized in two ways in diminutive structures: as upper mid, or as high vowels; see (3).

(3)	a.	meza + ziɲV → meziɲa, miziɲa	'table'
	b.	bolo + iɲV → boliɲo, buliɲo	'cake'

2 The IIA-BP Variety

- In the Italian Immigration Area in southern Brazil, Portuguese is in contact with a variety of Veneto (known locally as Talian); see Figure 1.

Figure 1: The Italian Immigration Area in southern Brazil

- The majority of Veneto speakers are from rural areas or are 60+ years old (see e.g., Frosi & Mioranza 1983, Tomiello 2005; Battisti et al. 2007). Among younger speakers, Portuguese monolingualism is predominant. Many (all ages) are heritage speakers of Veneto.

3 Questions

1. **How is the variation in diminutive constructions represented in IIA-BP speakers' grammars?**
2. **Does contact between Portuguese and Veneto play a role in such a variation?**

4 The Representation of Diminutive Structures

- In ST-BP, lower mid vowels are observed only in primarily stressed position. Suffixation causes lower mid vowels in the stem to raise to upper mid (Wetzels 1992); see (4).

(4)	a.	gɔ́lpe + ado → golpeádo	'strike, struck'
	b.	bɔ́la + ada → boláda	'ball, strike with ball'

- The preservation of lower mid vowels in diminutive structures indicates that the diminutive suffix is not incorporated into the phonological word (PWd) of the stem (Schwindt 2013); see (a) in Figure 2.
- Diminutive constructions have two stresses, unlike structures in which suffixation leads to vowel raising in the stem; compare (a) and (b) in Fig. 2.

Figure 2: Prosodic representation of diminutive structures (a) and other suffixed words (b) in ST-BP

- In IIA-BP, the variation in vowel quality in diminutive structures suggests the existence of two prosodic representations:
  - The ST-BP representation for the forms with lower mid vowel preservation; see (a) in Figure 3.
  - A representation in which the diminutive suffix is incorporated into the PWd of the stem; see (b) in Figure 3.

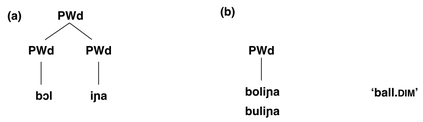

Figure 3: Prosodic representation of diminutive structures in IIA-BP

- The productions in Fig. 3(b) are consistent with a simple-PWd structure:
  - The incorporation of the diminutive suffix into the PWd of the stem causes the lower mid vowel in the stem to raise to upper mid: boliɲa; see (4).
  - The resulting structure provides context for vowel harmony. In BP, variable vowel harmony (unstressed upper mid vowels raise to high when there is a high vowel in the following syllable) is only attested PWd-internally (Bisol 1981): boliɲa → buliɲa; see (5).

(5)		ST-BP and IIA-BP:	
	a.	perigo → pirigo	'danger'
	b.	koruʒa → kuruʒa	'owl'
		IIA-BP only:	
	c.	boliɲa → buliɲa	'ball.DIM'

5 The role of contact

- The non-standard variables (see (2)) are produced by speakers who are either Portuguese-Veneto bilinguals or heritage speakers of Veneto (see Faggion 2006).
- Variation is observed at the individual level: The same speaker can produce the three possible IIA-BP forms (bɔliɲa ∼ boliɲa ∼ buliɲa).
- Segmental properties of the local Veneto variety are transferred into IIA-BP (see e.g., Frosi & Mioranza 1983; Tomiello 2005; Battisti et al. 2007).
- **Are prosodic properties of Veneto transferred into IIA-BP, namely the prosodic representation for diminutive structures?**

5.1 Diminutive structures in Veneto

- In Veneto, like in ST-BP, lower mid vowels are observed only in primarily stressed position (Zamboni 1974).
- Unlike in ST-BP, the insertion of a diminutive suffix in Veneto causes a lower mid vowel in the stem to raise to upper mid, which suggests that the suffix incorporates into the PWd of the stem; see (6).

(6)		stem + diminutive suffix:	
	a.	pɔrko + etV→ porketo	'pig'
		stem + non-diminutive suffix:	
	d.	pɔrko + aro → porkaro	'pig house'

- In IIA-BP, contact with Veneto provides an additional prosodic representation for the diminutive suffix: as incorporating into the PWd of the stem.
- The quality of the stem vowel in diminutive structures depends on which representation of the suffix is selected.
- The IIA-BP data suggest that speakers can transfer prosodic representations in cases of language contact, which had been previously observed for cases of second language acquisition (e.g., Goad & White 2006).

6 Final Remarks

- The variation in the realization of stem vowels in structures with a diminutive suffix in IIA-BP is dependent on the availability of two prosodic representations for this suffix.
- The non-standard diminutive forms arise through contact with Veneto. Variable vowel harmony can apply when the diminutive construction corresponds to a simple PWd.
- **In contact situations, prosodic representations can be transferred from one language into the other.**

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